NEW YORK, UNITED STATES

Museum of Modern Art: Masterpieces

Twenty works that change the rules for bodies, objects and painted space.



A soup can repeats thirty-two times. A bed stands upright against a wall. Clocks soften, a rubber glove shares a setting with a classical head, and a sofa appears in a jungle. The ordinary object survives each of these changes; in fact, recognition makes the change more noticeable.

This selection from the Museum of Modern Art follows several ways of disturbing the familiar. Some artists alter a thing's shape, others its company, scale or use. Still others remove recognisable objects altogether and leave colour or the passage of paint to organise attention. These are not successive steps towards one destination. Comparing them shows how many different problems can sit beneath the convenient label of modern art.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/museum-modern-art-new-york

The selection · 20

1. The Starry Night
   Vincent van Gogh · Saint Rémy, June 1889
2. Les Demoiselles d'Avignon
   Pablo Picasso · Paris, June-July 1907
3. The Persistence of Memory
   Salvador Dalí · 1931
4. Broadway Boogie Woogie
   Piet Mondrian · 1942–43
5. The Sleeping Gypsy
   Henri Rousseau · 1897
6. The Dream
   Henri Rousseau · 1910
7. Campbell's Soup Cans
   Andy Warhol · 1962
8. One: Number 31, 1950
   Jackson Pollock · 1950
9. I and the Village
   Marc Chagall · 1911
10. The Song of Love
    Giorgio de Chirico · 1914
11. The City Rises
    Umberto Boccioni · 1910
12. Twittering Machine
    Paul Klee · 1922
13. Abstract Painting, Blue
    Ad Reinhardt · 1952
14. Dance (I)
    Henri Matisse · Paris, Boulevard des Invalides, early 1909
15. Actor's Mask
    Paul Klee · 1924
16. Agapanthus
    Claude Monet · 1914-26
17. Agony
    Arshile Gorky · 1947
18. American Landscape
    Charles Sheeler · 1930
19. Bather
    Henri Matisse · Cavalière, summer 1909
20. Bed
    Robert Rauschenberg · 1955

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The Starry Night

Vincent van Gogh

Saint Rémy, June 1889 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Vincent van Gogh. The Starry Night. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The town occupies a comparatively small area beneath the turning sky. Van Gogh joins separate stars through repeated curves and rings, giving the darkness between them an activity of its own. The tall cypress connects the foreground with this upper field. The painting's force can be examined in that distribution of space without treating every stroke as a symptom of its maker's life.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 472.1941

02 / 20

Les Demoiselles d'Avignon

Pablo Picasso

Paris, June-July 1907 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Pablo Picasso. The girls of Avignon. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/the-girls-of-avignon-1907 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

Five figures face the viewer, but their bodies do not settle into one continuous room or one consistent method of representation. Angular planes break across flesh and surrounding space, while the faces differ sharply in treatment. Picasso keeps the group confrontationally present even as its spatial agreement collapses. Identifying the women does not resolve the incompatible ways in which they are shown.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 333.1939

03 / 20

The Persistence of Memory

Salvador Dalí

1931 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Salvador Dalí. The Persistence of Memory. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

Dalí gives the soft watches precise edges and tangible surfaces. They are easy to recognise and impossible to use as ordinary clocks. The distant cliffs retain a firmer appearance, making the contrast more exact. The picture's uncertainty does not come from vague painting; it comes from recognisable things losing the physical properties on which their familiar functions depend.

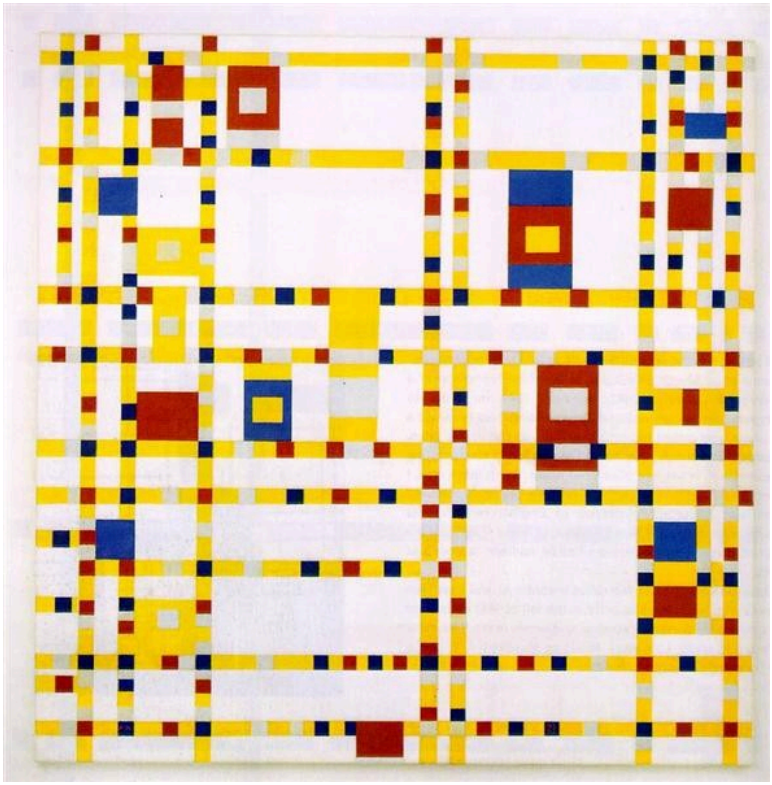
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 162.1934

04 / 20

Broadway Boogie Woogie

Piet Mondrian

1942–43 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Piet Mondrian. Broadway Boogie Woogie. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Small coloured squares interrupt the yellow grid, preventing the lines from functioning as uninterrupted boundaries. Mondrian keeps the right-angled order but gives it a restless internal pulse. The title associates the work with a city and a musical rhythm; neither requires a literal street scene. Movement can be suggested through the spacing of interruptions on an otherwise still surface.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 73.1943

05 / 20

The Sleeping Gypsy

Henri Rousseau

1897 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Henri Rousseau. The Sleeping Gypsy. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The lion leans towards the sleeping woman without completing an attack. Her instrument and vessel remain beside her, sharply identifiable in the open landscape. Rousseau suspends the scene at the point where proximity could mean danger, curiosity or something the image does not explain. The title names the sleeper using the artist's historical wording; it does not make the scene an ethnographic record.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 646.1939

06 / 20

The Dream

Henri Rousseau

1910 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Henri Rousseau. The Dream. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The sofa makes this jungle impossible to mistake for an unarranged encounter with nature. Rousseau places a familiar indoor object among oversized leaves, animals and a musician. Each part can be examined clearly, even though the whole resists ordinary explanation. The setting remains persuasive as an invented picture precisely because its details do not need to become plausible geography.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 252.1954

07 / 20

Campbell's Soup Cans

Andy Warhol

1962 · Acrylic with metallic enamel paint on canvas, 32 panels · Museum of Modern Art



Andy Warhol. Campbell's Soup Cans. WikiArt source label: Andy Warhol Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/andy-warhol/campbells-soup-cans-1962 · Andy Warhol Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The repeated design makes the changing soup varieties conspicuous. These thirty-two canvases were painted by hand, despite their resemblance to printed commercial images. Warhol's original display placed them on shelves like groceries. Repetition therefore does more than produce a pattern: it changes the question from how one can is represented to how almost identical goods acquire their small distinctions.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 476.1996.1-32

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One: Number 31, 1950

Jackson Pollock

1950 · Enamel and oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



One: Number 31. WikiArt; Jackson Pollock. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Jackson Pollock

The loops and threads of paint do not converge on a principal figure. Pollock leaves crossings, breaks and successive layers available across the broad field. Instead of looking through those marks to a depicted object, attention follows their passage over the canvas. The absence of a conventional subject does not remove structure; it relocates structure in the relations among the marks.

Object source · Open artwork

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I and the Village

Marc Chagall

1911 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Marc Chagall. I and the Village. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The green-faced man and the animal meet eye to eye above small houses and figures. Chagall allows different scales to coexist, while circles and diagonals connect areas that would not fit a single measured space. The exchange between the two large faces gives this displaced world an intimate centre. The village can be present as an association without being reconstructed as a panorama.

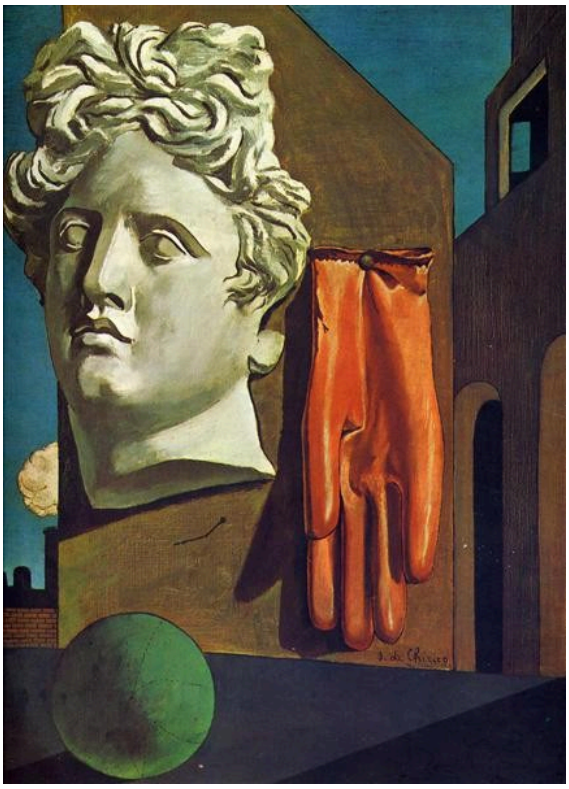
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 146.1945

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The Song of Love

Giorgio de Chirico

1914 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Giorgio de Chirico; WikiArt; Public domain (WikiArt label). Source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

A classical head, rubber glove and green ball occupy a setting whose perspective is easier to understand than its contents. De Chirico withholds the practical reason for their meeting. The train in the distance belongs to another kind of everyday movement, yet does not explain the foreground. The objects' clarity keeps the puzzle specific rather than dissolving it into general dreaminess.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 950.1979

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The City Rises

Umberto Boccioni

1910 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Umberto Boccioni. The City Rises. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The red horse's effort spreads into the strokes surrounding workers and construction. Boccioni makes it difficult to separate a body in motion from the urban activity around it. Edges blur where a more descriptive view might distinguish each task. The city is represented through physical strain rather than through a completed skyline: building is still an action taking place.

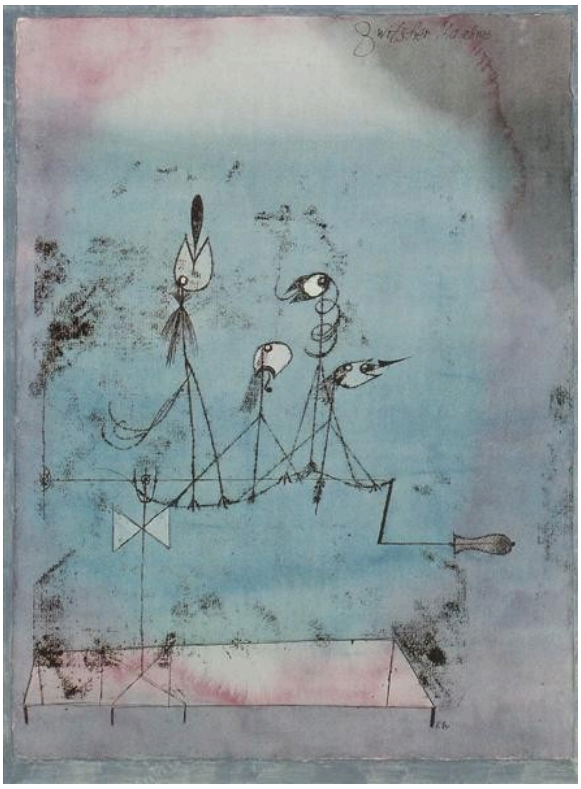
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 507.1951

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Twittering Machine

Paul Klee

1922 · Museum of Modern Art



Paul Klee. Twittering Machine. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The crank gives Klee's birdlike figures a troubling shared mechanism. Their thin, individual bodies remain comic and fragile, but the device suggests that sound or movement could be operated from outside. The drawing never needs to become a workable invention. A few connecting lines are enough to make living creatures and mechanical control occupy the same small structure.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Abstract Painting, Blue

Ad Reinhardt

1952 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Ad Reinhardt. Abstract Painting (Blue). Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

At first the blue can seem continuous. Subdued rectangles gradually divide it into darker and greenish passages, with no emphatic outline to announce their importance. Reinhardt makes a familiar act of looking for the subject give way to distinguishing neighbouring colours. A reproduction may change those close values, so its apparent simplicity should not be treated as the work's final measure.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 427.1981

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Dance (I)

Henri Matisse

Paris, Boulevard des Invalides, early 1909 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Henri Matisse. Dance (I). Image credit: Henri Matisse; Source credit: MoMA. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The reaching hands nearly fail to close the ring. Matisse leaves the setting spare enough for that small gap and the uneven spaces between bodies to carry the movement. Five figures do not become a mechanically repeated pattern. Their connection requires effort, making the circle appear maintained in motion rather than laid out as a finished emblem.

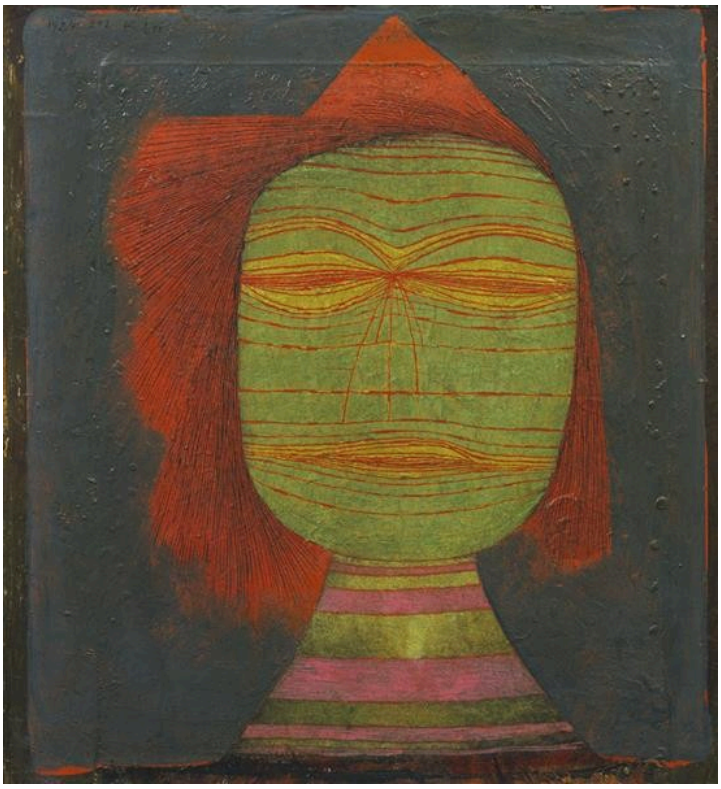
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 201.1963

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Actor's Mask

Paul Klee

1924 · Oil on canvas mounted on board · Museum of Modern Art



Paul Klee. Actor's Mask. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Thin divisions turn the green face into a constructed surface. Eyes and mouth remain sufficient for recognition even when they do not settle into an easy expression. Klee places a person-like image between two categories: a face to be read and an object to be worn. The title keeps performance in view without supplying a character or a story.

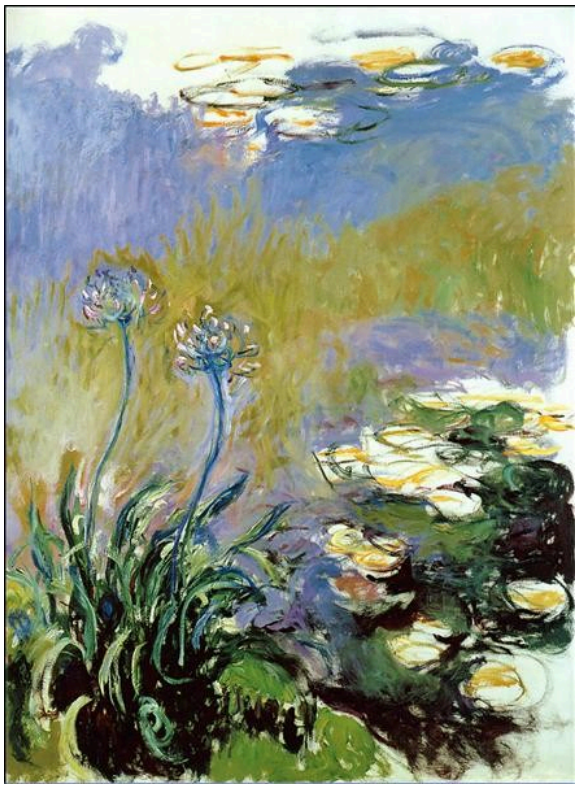
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 616.1967

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Agapanthus

Claude Monet

1914-26 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Claude Monet. Agapanthus. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The near flowers and reflected growth share Monet's long, overlapping marks. Clear outlines do not consistently separate plant, water and distance. Recognising the scene requires following changes within the handling rather than finding a boundary around each leaf. The overlapping marks keep that search close to the surface, making the garden less a surveyable place than a densely occupied field of colour.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 527.1992

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Agony

Arshile Gorky

1947 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Arshile Gorky. Agony. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Gorky's thin contours approach recognisable bodies and fragments without fixing them completely. Red and black shapes gather unevenly against the brownish ground. The title supplies a painful association, but not an illustrated event that can be decoded once and left behind. The painting allows bodily suggestions to persist in forms that remain capable of being read otherwise.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 88.1950

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American Landscape

Charles Sheeler

1930 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Charles Sheeler. American Landscape. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

Still water and sharply placed structures give Sheeler's factory complex an unusual composure. The small boat offers a measure against the industrial forms. Unlike Boccioni's construction scene, this view suppresses the strain of operation. The machinery appears settled within a carefully spaced landscape, raising a useful distinction between depicting a place of work and depicting the work performed there.

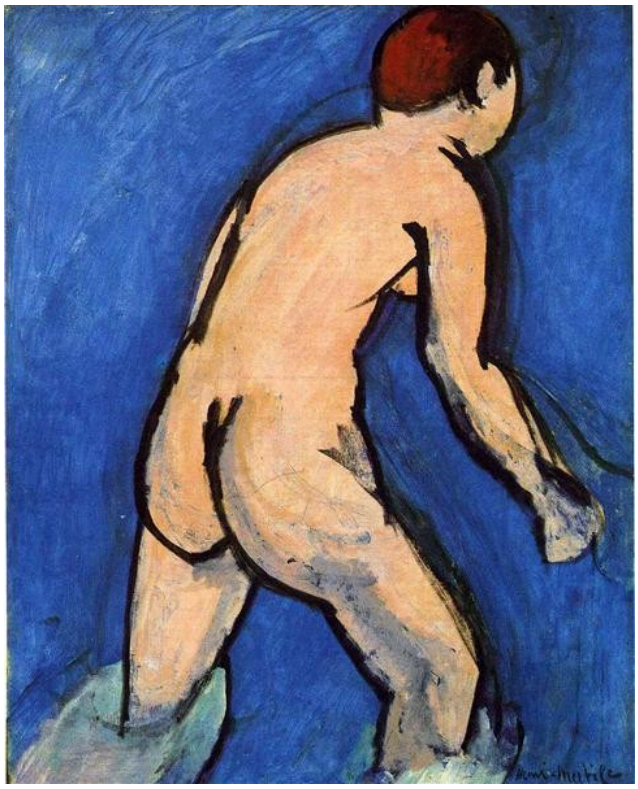
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 166.1934

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Bather

Henri Matisse

Cavalière, summer 1909 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Henri Matisse. Bather. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The turned back and large limbs retain bodily weight without elaborate anatomical shading. Matisse assigns much of that work to firm contours and broad blue and green areas. The figure remains physically present even as descriptive detail is reduced. Simplification here can be judged by what it preserves, not merely by counting what has been left out.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 17.1936

20 / 20

Bed

Robert Rauschenberg

1955 · Oil and pencil on pillow, quilt, and sheet on wood supports · Museum of Modern Art



Robert Rauschenberg. Bed. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The pillow, sheet and quilt are actual bedding, not painted imitations. Rauschenberg marks them with oil and pencil and sets them upright on wooden supports. They retain their domestic identity while their new position makes ordinary use impossible. The work does not let the viewer decide comfortably between furnishing and painting; each category continues to interfere with the other.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 79.1989

Keep the differences in view

Warhol repeats an image of an object; Rauschenberg uses the object itself. Dalí changes physical behaviour; de Chirico changes company. Distinguishing these operations gives more to discuss than calling them all strange. Use the museum's current records for display information: this selection connects ideas and works, not guaranteed stops in a particular installation.

Further reading

Pablo Picasso: A Retrospective

Edited by William Rubin · Digitized catalogue under Publications · English

MoMA’s digitized Picasso retrospective catalogue places Les Demoiselles d’Avignon among studies and later works. Comparing them makes the painting’s departures from conventional figure drawing easier to follow.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Museum of Modern Art: Masterpieces